

**FITNESSWISE**

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Tapering towards high performance

A taper is a period in an **athlete's periodised programme** during which intensity, volume, and frequency are adjusted to stimulate performance gains.

All athletes train to compete. More importantly, they train to win at every opportunity. Why else would they dedicate hours of training each day simply to qualify or play second fiddle to someone else?

Whether the athletes' season consists of one competition or several, it is imperative that they deliver their best performances at the highest levels and emerge victorious. One way coaches and support staff can help ensure athletes are physically and mentally prepared is by implementing a 'taper phase', something that has not always been taken seriously due to ignorance or lack of knowledge. One of the major aspects of performance is the combination of tapering and recovery for peak performance at the right time.

A taper is a period in an athlete's periodised programme during which intensity, volume, and frequency are adjusted to stimulate performance gains. During a taper period, the goal should be to maintain high levels of game adaptation while minimising fatigue as competition approaches.

The average improvement for a trained athlete who is given appropriate tapering is zero to six per cent, depending on the sport and skill. Elite athletes, being closer to their 'performance ceiling', tend to experience slightly smaller percentage improvements (ranging from half a per cent to three per cent). The tapering phase of a periodised programme should begin two to three weeks before competition. Here are a few key essentials to consider when developing a competition taper:

Volume

Volume refers to the amount of work done (sets, reps, distance, time, etc.). An expert on recovery and performance, Inigo Mujika, suggests a 40 to 60 per cent

reduction in volume over two to three weeks. It is important to note that there should be an accumulation of volume throughout the training plan to allow for meaningful reductions. Failing to accumulate sufficient volume can result in decreased performance when tapering by the suggested 40-60 per cent. If you reduce volume too much from an already low volume of work, the training stimulus may be insufficient.

Intensity

Intensity refers to the percentage of effort in relation to the maximum rep. Over the course of a training cycle, intensity should gradually increase until the taper period. Maintaining stable intensity while reducing volume during the taper can help achieve the goal of minimising fatigue while preserving and enhancing strength and power.

Frequency

Frequency denotes how many training sessions an athlete performs within a set timeframe. During a competition-tapering phase, frequency, like intensity, should remain relatively consistent, provided the athlete can manage it (with a maximum reduction of 15-20 per cent if necessary). For example, elite